

40

Balaam

The hired prophet who came to curse Israel and could only bless.

Balaam son of Beor was a famous seer from Pethor, near the Euphrates River. When Israel camped on the plains of Moab, Balak king of Moab offered him rich rewards to curse them. God told Balaam not to go, then allowed him to go but only to speak God's word. On the way, his donkey saw the angel of the LORD blocking the road and spoke to him. Three times Balak built altars, and three times Balaam blessed Israel instead. His fourth oracle foretold "a Star out of Jacob." Yet the New Testament remembers Balaam as a man who loved money. He later advised Moab to lead Israel into sin at Peor, and he died in battle.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Bil'am</i> . Its meaning is uncertain
Family	Son of Beor (Numbers 22:5), spelled Bosor in 2 Peter 2:15, KJV
Home	Pethor, by the Euphrates (Numbers 22:5; 23:7)
Role	Seer for hire; a "soothsayer" (Joshua 13:22)
When	c. 1406 BC on the early date (see the Timeline note)
Key people	Balak king of Moab, the princes of Moab and Midian
Main passages	Numbers 22–24; 31:8, 16
New Testament	2 Peter 2:15–16; Jude 11; Revelation 2:14

"God is not a man, that he should lie; neither the son of man, that he should repent: hath he said, and shall he not do it? or hath he spoken, and shall he not make it good?"

Numbers 23:19, KJV

The life of Balaam

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the early Exodus date, with Israel on the plains of Moab c. 1406 BC. On the late date, move them about 185 years later. The order of events after Numbers 24 comes from Numbers 31.

- | | |
|---|---|
| c. 1406 BC
<i>At Pethor</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Summoned by Balak
Moab is afraid of Israel. Balak sends elders with "the rewards of divination" to hire Balaam. God tells him, "Thou shalt not curse the people: for they are blessed."
<i>Numbers 22:1-14</i></div></div> |
| c. 1406 BC
<i>At Pethor</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Sent the second time
Balak sends greater princes and promises great honor. Balaam says he cannot go beyond the LORD's word, yet asks again. God lets him go but only to speak what he is told. <i>Numbers 22:15-21</i></div></div> |
| c. 1406 BC
<i>On the road</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>The donkey and the angel
The angel of the LORD blocks the road three times. The donkey turns aside and is beaten, then speaks. Balaam's eyes are opened, and he sees the angel with a drawn sword. <i>Numbers 22:22-35</i></div></div> |
| c. 1406 BC
<i>Hills of Moab</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Blesses Israel
From three high places Balak offers sacrifices, and three times Balaam blesses Israel. A fourth oracle foretells a star and sceptre from Israel. <i>Numbers 22:36-24:25</i></div></div> |
| c. 1406 BC
<i>Peor</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Counsels sin
Israel falls into immorality and idol worship with the women of Moab and Midian. Moses later says this happened "through the counsel of Balaam." <i>Numbers 25:1-3; 31:16</i></div></div> |
| c. 1406 BC
<i>Midian</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Killed in battle
Israel wars against Midian. Balaam son of Beor is killed with the sword along with the five kings of Midian. <i>Numbers 31:8; Joshua 13:22</i></div></div> |

Key activities

Christians and Jews have long debated Balaam. Was he a true prophet of the LORD who went wrong, or a pagan diviner whom God used against his will? Readers also ask why God allowed him to go (Numbers 22:20) and then was angry that he went (Numbers 22:22).

-
- 1 Sought God's word.** He asked the LORD and at first refused to go. *Numbers 22:8-13*
 - 2 Kept the door open for reward.** He said he could not go beyond God's word "if Balak would give me his house full of silver and gold," yet he asked God a second time. *Numbers 22:18-19*
 - 3 Was rebuked by a donkey.** "The LORD opened the mouth of the ass," and Balaam finally saw the angel. *Numbers 22:28-31*
 - 4 Blessed instead of cursing.** He said, "How shall I curse, whom God hath not cursed?" *Numbers 23:7-10*
 - 5 Spoke of God's faithfulness.** He declared that God does not lie or change his mind. *Numbers 23:18-24*
 - 6 Foretold a coming ruler.** "There shall come a Star out of Jacob, and a Sceptre shall rise out of Israel." *Numbers 24:15-19*
 - 7 Taught Balak to trap Israel.** His counsel led Israel into sin at Baal-peor. *Numbers 31:16; Revelation 2:14*
-

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Balaam.

Old Testament

Numbers 22-24	The main account
Numbers 31:8, 16	His death and his role at Peor
Deuteronomy 23:4-5	God "turned the curse into a blessing"
Joshua 13:22; 24:9-10	A soothsayer God would not listen to
Nehemiah 13:2; Micah 6:5	Balak's plot and Balaam's answer recalled

New Testament

2 Peter 2:15-16	He "loved the wages of unrighteousness"
Jude 11	"The error of Balaam for reward"
Revelation 2:14	He "taught Balac to cast a stumblingblock"
Echo: Revelation 22:16	Many see Numbers 24:17's star fulfilled in Jesus

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Balaam's donkey see that Balaam could not (Numbers 22:22-31)?
2. *Understand:* Balaam spoke true words yet is remembered as a warning. What does that teach about gifts and character?
3. *Apply:* Is there a decision where you keep hoping God will change his mind?
4. *Apply:* Where might money or approval be pulling you away from what is right?